FOX AUTOMOTIVE SALES ACADEMY

Module 9: Protect the Yes

From customer commitment to delivery, CSI, referrals, and long-term ownership.

Learning Objectives

- Understand that the sale is not protected until the customer leaves confident, informed, and excited.
- Use assumptive continuation after commitment instead of reopening the decision.
- Gather required documents and customer information without slowing momentum.
- Perform a clean salesperson-to-manager and salesperson-to-finance handoff.
- Use the three-minute drill to prepare the business manager with useful customer context.
- Keep customers informed during wait time to prevent buyer remorse and CSI damage.
- Inspect the vehicle before and after prep so the customer never discovers a problem first.
- Deliver the vehicle based on the customer comfort level and complete key setup items.
- Set expectations, document promises, and prevent broken commitments.
- Complete next-day follow-up, CSI conversation, referral request, and long-term ownership contact.

1. The Yes Is Not the Finish Line

Many salespeople relax the moment the customer says yes. That is a mistake. The customer commitment starts a new phase of the sale. The emotional pressure changes, the customer begins thinking about time, paperwork, money, insurance, delivery, and whether they made the right decision. If the salesperson becomes loose, slow, or uncertain, buyer remorse can enter immediately.

The job after yes is to protect momentum. The salesperson should congratulate the customer, reinforce the decision, and move the process forward confidently. This is not the time to ask questions that make the customer pause. It is the time to lead the customer into ownership.

> **Core Principle**
>
> A yes can still become a no if the process breaks afterward.

2. Assumptive Continuation

After the customer commits, the salesperson should not ask, "Do you want to do this today?" or "Do you want to take it home now?" That type of question reopens a decision the customer already made. It gives the customer permission to pause, delay, or rethink the process.

The correct approach is assumptive continuation. The salesperson moves forward professionally as if the customer is buying now, while still handling legitimate time constraints with structure and management involvement.

Performance Standard

Once the customer says yes, act like professionals moving the process forward - not salespeople hoping the deal survives.

Acceptable Language

- Congratulations. I am excited for you. Let us get the next steps started so we can make this smooth.
- Great choice. What I am going to do now is gather a few items so we can get everything moving.
- Perfect. I will get this started with my manager and the business office so we can keep the process moving.

Unacceptable Language

- Do you want to do this today?
- Do you want to take it home now?
- Are you sure you want to move forward?
- This might take a while, so do you want to come back?

Standard Line

Do not reopen the decision after the customer has already made it.

3. Required Document and Information Collection

Once the customer commits, the salesperson must gather the information needed to keep the deal moving. Missing documents should not create confusion. The salesperson should collect what is available, identify what is missing, document what is owed, and keep management and finance informed.

The salesperson should not assume the customer has everything. Customers often do not expect to buy that day. They may not have a title, registration, proof of insurance, second key, payoff information, release of lien, or incentive qualification documents. The salesperson stays calm and continues the process.

Item Needed	Why It Matters	Training Standard
Driver license	Required for credit, paperwork, identity, and delivery	Get it immediately after commitment.
Credit application	Needed when financing or leasing	Do not delay. Move directly into the credit application process.
Proof of insurance	Required before delivery in most situations	Gather early or help customer secure/update it.
Registration / plate status	Determines transfer plate or new plate needs	Verify whether customer is transferring or needs a new plate.
Title / release of lien	Needed when trade is owned free and clear	If missing, document what must be brought back.
Payoff request / lienholder	Needed when trade is financed	Verify lender and payoff so numbers remain accurate.
Incentive qualification documents	May affect final structure	Identify and collect any required proof before delivery.
Trade keys and equipment	Affects trade completion and value	Confirm before final delivery whenever possible.

Missing Item Rule

Incomplete documents should pause delivery - not pause momentum. Complete what can be completed now, document what is missing, and clearly schedule the next step.

4. When the Customer Does Not Have Time

Some customers commit but do not have enough time to complete everything immediately. They may not have expected to purchase. They may have work, family obligations, or missing documents. This situation must be handled with structure, not panic.

The salesperson should involve the sales manager and business manager quickly. The goal is to protect the commitment window, complete as much as possible, and schedule the customer back as soon as possible. The customer should not leave with unclear expectations.

Core Principle

If the customer cannot finish now, do not let the deal become vague. Convert the commitment into a scheduled next step.

5. Salesperson to Sales Manager Handoff

After commitment, the salesperson must return to the sales manager with a complete and accurate update. The manager needs to know that the customer said yes, what structure was agreed to, what documents are present, what is missing, and whether anything could prevent delivery.

A weak handoff creates wasted time. A strong handoff creates speed, accuracy, and confidence. The salesperson should not walk into the manager office with excitement but no information.

Manager Handoff Standard

The customer said yes. The deal structure is confirmed. The documents are being gathered. The manager knows what is complete and what still needs attention.

6. The Three-Minute Drill: Salesperson to Finance

The business manager should never walk into a deal blind. The salesperson has spent time learning the customer, their needs, their concerns, their lifestyle, and their emotional state. That information should be transferred quickly and professionally before the finance presentation.

The three-minute drill is not gossip. It is a structured handoff that protects customer trust and gives finance the context needed to serve the customer properly. Salespeople plant seeds. They do not sell products. Finance presents the products.

Core Principle

Salespeople plant seeds. They do not sell finance products.

Finance Needs to Know	Examples
Customer mood and style	Excited, anxious, payment sensitive, skeptical, rushed, relationship oriented
Vehicle usage	Primary driver, kids, commute, long trips, dirt roads, high mileage use
Rate or payment sensitivity	Customer asked about rate, monthly investment, upfront investment, or structure
Trade appraisal observations	Condition concerns, tires, glass, missing keys, payoff or negative equity

Protection history	Bought warranty before, had a repair issue, disliked prior coverage, had GAP claim
Product seeds planted	Interior protection for kids, tire and wheel for large wheels or road conditions, service contract for long-term ownership
Customer hot buttons	Safety, reliability, payment, ownership cycle, convenience, technology, maintenance

Fail Condition

Dropping the deal and running is not a finance handoff. It is abandonment.

7. Controlling the Wait

The wait between commitment, finance, prep, and delivery is one of the most dangerous parts of the sale. The customer has said yes, but they are not finished. If they do not know what is happening, they begin to wonder how long it will take, whether they made the right decision, and whether anyone still cares about them.

The salesperson does not have to sit with the customer every second, but the customer must feel informed. Silence from the dealership feels like neglect. Updates create confidence.

Reality Check

Buyer remorse often starts when the customer is waiting and nobody is explaining the next step.

What the Salesperson Should Do During the Wait

- Make sure the vehicle is moving into prep or detail.
- Check on the customer before they have to ask for an update.
- Explain the next step clearly and confidently.
- Continue ownership language and reinforce the decision when appropriate.
- Gather referrals naturally if the customer is engaged and comfortable.
- Avoid acting uncomfortable about the wait.

What Should Never Be Said

- Sorry this is taking so long.
- Finance is backed up again.
- Detail is slow today.
- I do not know what is going on.
- This always takes forever.

Standard Line

If you become uncomfortable with the wait, the customer will become uncomfortable with the wait.

8. Prep and Inspection Discipline

Vehicle prep is not something salespeople hand off and forget. The salesperson owns the customer experience, and part of that ownership is making sure the vehicle is inspected before prep and again before the customer sees it after prep.

One of the biggest delivery mistakes is allowing the customer to discover a scratch, dent, detail miss, missing item, or surprise before the salesperson sees it. That immediately damages trust and turns an exciting delivery into a problem conversation.

Core Principle

Never let the customer discover the problem before you do.

Inspection Point	Before Prep	After Prep
Exterior condition	Walk around for damage, scratches, dents, wheels, glass	Confirm vehicle is clean and no new or missed damage is visible
Interior condition	Check seats, mats, smell, personal items, packaging	Confirm clean delivery condition and no mess left behind
Fuel / charge	Identify if it needs fuel or charge	Confirm ready for customer departure
Keys / manuals	Confirm key count and materials	Confirm customer receives what is owed
Accessories / we-owes	Verify what was promised	Confirm completed or documented with timeline
Plates / registration	Confirm plate path	Confirm plate or temporary permit handled correctly

Delivery Timing Standard

The ideal target from yes to delivery is one hour or less when the customer, documents, finance, and vehicle prep allow it.

9. Guided Feature Delivery

Delivery is not a technology lecture. The goal is to make the customer comfortable, confident, and excited. Some customers want every feature explained. Others only want the basics. A professional salesperson adjusts the depth of delivery based on the customer.

The salesperson should ask how comfortable the customer is with the vehicle and then guide the explanation accordingly. The customer should not be overwhelmed. The customer should leave knowing how to use the features that matter most.

Core Principle

Delivery depth should match the customer comfort level.

High-Value Delivery Touches

- Set the clock and confirm basic settings.
- Pair the customer phone and confirm Bluetooth works.
- Connect OEM apps and connected services when available.
- Explain key safety features in plain language.
- Show the customer where important controls are located.
- If there is a trade, consider setting presets or comfort settings similar to the old vehicle as a personal touch.
- Confirm the customer knows how to fuel or charge the vehicle if applicable.

Standard Line

Small personalization creates big emotional connection.

10. Service Introduction and Ownership Orientation

The customer should leave knowing where to go after the sale. Service introduction is not a formality. It connects the customer to the store, improves retention, and reduces anxiety when the first service visit arrives.

At minimum, the salesperson should walk the customer through service, explain hours, night drop, appointment process, first service interval, and who to contact if they need help. The goal is not to overwhelm. The goal is to remove uncertainty.

Core Principle

Customers should leave knowing where to go after the sale.

11. Promise Management: Under-Promise and Over-Deliver

CSI is often damaged by broken expectations, not by the original issue. A customer can tolerate a delay if it was explained clearly. A customer becomes frustrated when they were promised something unrealistic, vague, or not documented.

Salespeople should not promise anything they cannot guarantee. If something is uncertain, it must be framed honestly. If something is owed, it must be documented. If timing is estimated, it should be conservative.

Core Principle

Do not promise what you cannot control.

Good Expectation Language

- I expect this to take about an hour. If it moves faster, great, but I would rather set the right expectation.
- I am going to document that so everyone knows exactly what was promised.
- I do not want to guess. Let me verify that before I commit to it.
- Here is what we can do today, and here is what we will need to complete when you return.

Bad Expectation Language

- That should be no problem, without checking.
- It will only take a few minutes, when the salesperson does not know.
- We will take care of it, without documenting what that means.
- Do not worry about it, when there is no clear plan.

Standard Line

Customers remember broken promises longer than great negotiations.

12. When Something Goes Wrong After Delivery

Problems after delivery must be owned, not passed around. The salesperson should attempt to help and gather information. If they cannot resolve it, they involve the sales manager. If the sales manager cannot resolve it, the general manager is involved. The customer should not feel bounced between departments.

Core Principle

We do not pass problems around. We own them until they are solved.

Level	Responsibility	Goal
Salesperson	Listen, document, attempt simple correction, communicate clearly	Make the customer feel heard and supported
Sales Manager	Step in when issue impacts delivery, promise, payment, timing, or dissatisfaction	Create solution or path forward
General Manager	Escalate when issue is unresolved, high risk, or damaging to customer trust	Protect customer relationship and store reputation

13. The Next-Day Follow-Up and CSI Conversation

The first follow-up should happen the next day. The purpose is not to beg for a survey. The purpose is to thank the customer, make sure they are comfortable, identify any problems early, ask for referrals, and prepare them for the survey in a professional way.

CSI is a report card. It tells the salesperson and the store how well the customer experience was delivered. If the customer cannot give perfect scores, the salesperson should know why before the survey is submitted so the store has a chance to correct the issue.

Core Principle

Good CSI is not created by asking for good CSI. It is created by delivering the experience and correcting issues before the survey arrives.

Next-Day Follow-Up Objectives

- Thank the customer for their business.
- Confirm they are enjoying the vehicle and know how to use key features.
- Remind them that you are available if they need anything.
- Ask if they know anyone else you could help.
- Explain that the survey is your report card and that you pride yourself on a great experience.
- Ask them to tell you if anything would prevent them from giving great scores so the issue can be corrected.

CSI Language

My survey is my report card. I take pride in making sure you had a great experience. If there is anything that would keep you from giving great scores, please let me know so I can try to correct it.

14. Recovery Mode Before the Survey

If the customer sounds unhappy before the survey arrives, the salesperson should not wait. They should notify the sales manager and move into recovery mode. Waiting until after a bad survey is submitted is too late.

Recovery mode means identifying the issue, documenting it, involving the right manager, setting expectations, and following up until the customer knows what is happening. This does not guarantee perfect CSI, but it gives the dealership the best chance to protect the relationship.

Performance Standard

If the customer sounds unhappy, get management involved before the survey arrives.

Two-Week CSI Check

If the customer has not received or mentioned the CSI survey within approximately two weeks, the salesperson should reach out. The goal is to check on ownership, confirm there are no unresolved concerns, and ask whether they received the survey.

15. Reviews, Referrals, and Reputation

Reviews are the heartbeat of the internet. Many customers look at dealership reviews before they ever visit the store. A strong delivery and follow-up process supports not only CSI but future traffic, trust, and reputation.

Referrals are not free because they require no work. They are earned through customer experience. A customer who feels informed, respected, and cared for is more likely to refer friends and family.

Core Principle

Referrals are earned before they are asked for.

Referral Timing

- During waiting time if the customer is engaged and excited.
- During next-day follow-up after confirming they are happy.
- After a problem is resolved successfully.
- During long-term ownership touches when trust has been maintained.

16. Long-Term Ownership Contact

The salesperson should remain the customer touchpoint throughout the ownership cycle. If a salesperson disappears for three years and then calls to ask about trading, the call feels uncomfortable. If the salesperson has maintained contact, the trade-cycle conversation feels natural.

Long-term contact includes birthdays, purchase anniversaries, service visits, lease maturity, warranty expiration, mileage checkpoints, and ownership check-ins. The goal is not to annoy the customer. The goal is to remain the trusted automotive contact.

Standard Line

Transactional salespeople chase deals. Relationship salespeople build careers.

17. Transactional vs Relationship Salespeople

Transactional Salesperson	Relationship Salesperson
Focuses only on the sale in front of them	Focuses on the customer lifecycle
Disappears after delivery	Stays connected after delivery
Asks for referrals awkwardly	Earns referrals through experience
Calls only when they want another sale	Creates ongoing touchpoints
May win individual deals	Builds retention, referrals, and repeat business

Final Message to the Sales Professional

The sale is not complete when the customer says yes. The sale is protected when the customer leaves confident, informed, excited, and clear on what happens next. How you handle the customer after commitment determines CSI, referrals, repeat business, and whether that customer sees you as a salesperson or as their long-term automotive contact.

Closing Line

Protect the yes. Deliver the experience. Own the relationship.